

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Lockheed Martin

Engineering Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

Lockheed Martin is the world's largest defence contractor, operating across four major business areas — Aero-nautics, Missiles & Fire Control, Rotary & Mission Systems, and Space — and producing some of the most complex, long-duration government programmes on earth. This guide consolidates the preparation tasks, signal areas, and strategic context needed to compete effectively across all relevant engineering roles.

PART I · WHAT LM ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Seniority Level

- **Intern** — At intern level, Lockheed Martin is almost entirely screening for citizenship (US citizenship is mandatory for clearance-required roles, which is most of them), academic technical grounding, and one thing that differentiates them sharply from SpaceX and Airbus: demonstrated ability to work within a structured, process-governed team environment. Desired intern attributes explicitly include the ability to work with multi-disciplined teams, organisational and communication skills, and the ability to build consensus among peers and effective relationships with team members. They are not screening for raw intellectual firepower or first-principles innovators at this stage — they are screening for people who will function well in a government contracting environment with defined processes, long programme timelines, and external customer oversight. *Zippia*
- **Mid-Level (0–5 years, associate/level 1–2)** — The process assesses technical skills and cultural fit, evaluating interpersonal skills and how well you align with Lockheed Martin's values and mission. At this level the specific filter is evidence that you can translate a requirement into an engineering deliverable and document it properly. Lockheed Martin mid-level engineers sit at the intersection of customer requirements, programme schedule, and technical implementation — and all three must be tracked and reported. Candidates who have worked only in informal environments (no requirements traceability, no configuration control, no documented test procedures) are at a structural disadvantage. The behavioral interview carries significant weight and is more dominant here than at SpaceX or Airbus. *Interview Query*
- **Senior (Level 3–5+)** — Senior candidates are expected to have extensive experience across the full spectrum of systems engineering activities — generating, decomposing, tracking, and verifying requirements; performing risk assessments; leading trade studies; writing SOWs and supplier specifications; and performing technical planning — while also having a practical understanding of Earned Value Measurement Systems (EVMS). At this level, Lockheed Martin is specifically looking for someone who can interface directly with the government customer, own a technical thread across a multi-year programme, and mentor junior engineers in doing the same. The ability to navigate the bureaucratic structure of a DoD programme — IPTs (Integrated Product Teams), CDRs, PDRs, programme reviews — is assumed knowledge, not a bonus. *LinkedIn*

Hands-On Signal Areas

Domain	Core Competencies Expected
Security Clearance	An existing Secret or Top Secret clearance is a significant differentiator at every level. If you currently hold a clearance at your present employer or through the military, it may be transferable. Military backgrounds are therefore common and valued. <i>Lockheed Martin</i>
Configuration Management	Working in a CM-controlled environment (IBM DOORS, Teamcenter/PDM, GitLab for defence, or similar) is a real signal. Experience working in a configuration management environment is listed as a basic qualification, not a desired skill — this is a baseline expectation at mid and senior levels. <i>Lockheed Martin</i>
Government Programme Familiarity	Experience on DoD, NASA, or allied-nation defence contracts — understanding of programme reviews, CDR/PDR structure, contract deliverables, and government customer interface — is a strong differentiator.
Requirements Traceability	The ability to write, decompose, and verify requirements in a traceable way (using tools or documented methods) matters far more at Lockheed Martin than at SpaceX.
EVMS Awareness	Earned Value Management experience and schedule performance management techniques are explicitly called out as differentiating skills for senior programme and systems engineering roles. <i>Build Submarines</i>
Domain Modelling Tools	MATLAB and domain-specific modelling tools (Simulink, MATLAB, DOORS, Teamcenter) appear consistently across F-35, space, and missile defence postings.
Sustainment & Lifecycle Thinking	Unlike SpaceX (build-test-iterate) or Airbus (certify and produce), LM programmes run for decades. Engineers who have thought about supportability, obsolescence management, and fleet sustainment — not just initial design — stand out.

How LM's Interview Format Differs from Standard Tech, Airbus, and SpaceX

- **The behavioral interview is the dominant filter**, more so than at any other major aerospace company. The typical process mirrors Glassdoor descriptions: an initial screen, a behavioral interview often in panel style using STAR questions, occasionally some light technical or skills assessment, and then background check and drug test. Unlike SpaceX — where technical depth is the primary screen — and Airbus — where the assessment centre structure balances group, presentation, and technical exercises — Lockheed Martin leans heavily on STAR behavioral questions and panel discussions. *Lockedinai*
- **The panel interview is standard, not exceptional.** Panel interviews involving multiple interviewers from different departments are common, allowing the team to assess how you interact with various stakeholders and how well you communicate your ideas. You will be watched for how you handle disagreement, how you communicate to a mixed technical/non-technical audience, and whether your interpersonal style fits a large, hierarchical, process-heavy organisation. *Interview Query*
- **There is no LeetCode, no take-home project, and typically no formal whiteboard problem.** There was no separate coding test or formal system design whiteboard, and no take-home project — evaluation leaned heavily on behavioral evidence and basic technical reasoning. For technical roles, the closest thing to a live technical test is a scenario-based discussion, sometimes using a sanitised block diagram or system architecture to prompt questions. *Lockedinai*

- **Security clearance eligibility is screened explicitly and early.** US citizenship is a hard gate. Existing clearances accelerate and simplify hiring significantly. If you are currently cleared, this is not a detail to bury in your resume — it belongs at the top.
- **The culture is more hierarchical and process-oriented** than either Airbus or SpaceX. Candidates who frame their experience as “I challenged my manager’s decision” or “I bypassed the process to go faster” may read poorly. Candidates who frame experience as “I escalated the right concern through the right channel and drove a documented resolution” read well. *Quora*

Honest caveat on format variation: Lockheed Martin has four major business areas (Aeronautics, Missiles & Fire Control, Rotary & Mission Systems, Space) and dozens of programme offices. The F-35 programme office in Fort Worth operates differently from Skunk Works in Palmdale, which operates differently from Space in Littleton, CO. Interview depth and format vary. Use Glassdoor filtered by site and division where possible.

PART II · 20 SPECIFIC PREPARATION TASKS

Intern Level

1. Build a STAR Answer Bank Mapped Explicitly to Lockheed Martin’s Published Values

3–4 h

Skill: Behavioral interview preparation for a defence contractor context

Objective: The interview is mostly behavioral questions using the STAR method, with the idea of demonstrating leadership behaviors in the context of prior role challenges. Lockheed Martin’s stated values — integrity, performance excellence, teamwork, and purposeful innovation — are not just decoration; interviewers are explicitly scoring answers against these. Generic STAR prep misses this. An answer that would be strong at SpaceX (“I moved fast and cut a process”) can be a negative signal here.

Done Signal: You have 8 written STAR stories (200–300 words each), each explicitly tagged to one of LM’s values, drawn from real experience. Each story has been spoken aloud and ends with a concrete, measurable result — not a cultural observation.

Source: Glassdoor

2. Understand the US Security Clearance Process, Levels, and What Disqualifies Candidates

2–3 h

Skill: Clearance eligibility self-assessment and informed conversation

Objective: Most Lockheed Martin engineering roles require at minimum a Secret clearance. This position requires a government security clearance; you must be a US Citizen for consideration. Interns are often sponsored for clearances during their internship. Knowing what the process involves, what is disclosed, and what questions to expect from a recruiter about clearance eligibility is basic professional preparedness. Interns who have no idea what a clearance involves look uninformed about the environment they are entering.

Done Signal: You can explain the difference between Confidential, Secret, and Top Secret clearances; know that SAR/SAP access requires additional adjudication; understand what the SF-86 covers at a high level; and can honestly assess whether anything in your background would require disclosure.

Source: Lockheed Martin

3. Learn the DoD Programme Acquisition Lifecycle at a Conceptual Level (Milestone A/B/C, CDR, PDR) 3 h

Skill: Government programme lifecycle literacy

Objective: Lockheed Martin engineers work on DoD programmes, not commercial products. The acquisition lifecycle (from Technology Maturation through Engineering Development to Production & Deployment) governs when reviews happen, what deliverables are required, and what “done” means. Interns who do not know what a CDR (Critical Design Review) or PDR (Preliminary Design Review) is will struggle to understand the context of their assigned work.

Done Signal: You can draw a simplified DoD acquisition lifecycle from memory, place CDR, PDR, and Milestone B/C in the right sequence, and explain what the engineering team must demonstrate at each gate to proceed.

4. Practise a Scenario-Based Block Diagram Question for Your Discipline 2–3 h

Skill: Real-time technical reasoning from system documentation

Objective: Interviewers pulled up a sanitised block diagram of a notional system and asked candidates to talk through how they would interpret it and where they would focus verification and integration efforts. This is the closest thing to a live technical test in LM interviews. It does not require domain-specific knowledge of the system — it requires the ability to read a system schematic and reason about it out loud.

Done Signal: You have sourced three unfamiliar block diagrams (avionics, mechanical system, electrical power, or similar) and practised a 5-minute verbal walk-through of each, including: what the system does, where the key interfaces are, and what you would verify first and why.

Source: Lockedinai

5. Prepare a Clear, Honest Answer to Questions About Citizenship, Clearance Eligibility, and Willingness to Relocate 1–2 h

Skill: Recruiter screen preparation for defence-specific screening questions

Objective: The initial questionnaire asked about clearance status, willingness to relocate, citizenship, and salary expectations before any technical conversation occurred. Candidates who give vague or unprepared answers to these questions create friction early. Candidates who know their clearance status (or lack thereof), can articulate their history clearly, and have a considered answer on relocation make the recruiter’s job easy — which is noticed.

Done Signal: You have written out your honest answers to: citizenship status, any foreign contacts or travel that would appear on an SF-86, current clearance status if any, and specific sites/locations you are and are not willing to relocate to. These answers are rehearsed and do not involve hesitation or vagueness.

Source: Lockedinai

6. Learn What ITAR and EAR Are and Why They Govern Your Work at LM 2 h

Skill: Export control regulatory awareness

Objective: International Traffic in Arms Regulations (ITAR) and Export Administration Regulations (EAR) govern what Lockheed Martin engineers can share, with whom, and under what conditions. Violations carry severe legal consequences. Every employee — regardless of role — must understand they cannot share technical information with foreign nationals without proper authorisation. Interns who have no idea these regulations exist are a liability.

Done Signal: You can explain in plain language what ITAR covers (defence articles and services on the US Munitions List), what EAR covers (dual-use items), why this matters in a collaborative or open-source context, and what “deemed export” means. 2 h

Mid-Level (0–5 years, associate through level 2)

All intern tasks still apply. The STAR stories must come from professional contexts. The DoD lifecycle knowledge (task 3) is expected to be operational, not conceptual — you should have worked in or near a programme office, not just read about the lifecycle.

7. Write a Traceability Matrix for a System You Have Worked On 4–5 h

Skill: Requirements-to-verification traceability documentation

Objective: Requirements verification traceability tools and the ability to establish verification methods are explicitly cited as highly helpful skills. Requirements traceability — showing that every requirement has a corresponding verification method and test result — is a basic artefact of every LM engineering programme. Mid-level engineers who cannot do this in a tool or in a spreadsheet are missing a fundamental LM-environment skill.

Done Signal: You have created a requirements traceability matrix (even in Excel or a simple table) for a real system you worked on, with at minimum 15 requirements, each tagged with: requirement source, derived or allocated status, verification method (test/analysis/inspection/demonstration), and verification status.

Source: LinkedIn

8. Study MIL-SPEC and MIL-STD Documentation Relevant to Your Discipline 5–6 h

Skill: DoD standards fluency

Objective: Lockheed Martin engineering deliverables are governed by military standards — MIL-STD-810 (environmental engineering), MIL-STD-461 (electromagnetic compatibility), MIL-HDBK-516 (airworthiness), MIL-STD-882 (system safety), and many others depending on the domain. Mid-level engineers are expected to know which standards apply to their work and what compliance means in practice. This is the defence-specific equivalent of DO-178C at Airbus.

Done Signal: For your specific discipline, you have identified the three most relevant MIL-STDs, can explain the scope of each, know what test or analysis they require, and can describe at least one situation where compliance with a standard drove a design or test decision.

9. Prepare Stories Demonstrating Process Compliance That Delivered a Better Engineering Outcome 2 h

Skill: Framing process adherence as engineering judgment, not just obedience

Objective: LM’s culture rewards working effectively within process — not around it. Mid-level candidates who frame their best work as “I bypassed the slow process” will not land well. The preferred framing is: “The process caught something that would have been missed” or “I used the established escalation path to resolve a technical conflict and the outcome was better for it.” This is almost the inverse of SpaceX.

Done Signal: You have two STAR stories where following or using a defined process (formal review, change control board, configuration management, documented test procedure) produced a measur-

ably better technical or programme outcome than cutting it would have.

2 h

10. Build a Working Understanding of Earned Value Management (EVMS) at the Conceptual Level

3–4 h

Skill: Cost and schedule performance measurement literacy

Objective: Earned Value Management is explicitly called out as a differentiating skill for LM engineering and planning roles. Even engineers who are not programme managers encounter EVMS reporting in DoD programmes — understanding what Schedule Performance Index (SPI) and Cost Performance Index (CPI) mean, and why a programme might have green cost but red schedule (or vice versa), is expected literacy at mid-level and above.

Done Signal: You can explain Planned Value, Earned Value, and Actual Cost from first principles; calculate SPI and CPI from a simple dataset; and explain what a CPI below 0.9 means for a programme's forecast at completion.

Source: *Build Submarines*

11. Prepare a Story of a Technical Disagreement — Resolved Through the Right Channels

1–2 h

Skill: Conflict resolution in a hierarchical, stakeholder-heavy environment

Objective: LM panel interviews explicitly probe conflict resolution. Critical thinking assessment and examples of how candidates deal with conflict are specifically requested. At LM the right answer is not “I convinced everyone” or “I moved fast without consensus” — it is “I documented my position, raised it through the appropriate channel, and the resolution was traceable.” The government customer and programme office structure means unilateral decisions carry significant risk.

Done Signal: You have a STAR story about a technical disagreement where you: identified the right channel to raise it (technical lead, chief engineer, change control board, etc.), made your case with documented evidence, and the outcome was traceable to a real engineering result — not just a relationship outcome.

Source: *Prosple*

12. Practise Translating a Vague Stakeholder Need into a Set of Formal Requirements

3 h

Skill: Requirements elicitation and formalisation

Objective: Lockheed Martin engineers interface with government programme offices whose stated needs are often vague, contradictory, or scope-expanding. The ability to take “the system should be easy to maintain in the field” and produce three verifiable, unambiguous SHALL statements from it is a daily mid-level engineering task. Interviewers test this with scenario questions.

Done Signal: You have practised with five vague stakeholder statements (written from memory or sourced from job descriptions), and for each produced three SHALL-style requirements that are: specific, measurable, unambiguous, and testable. Each requirement names what is being measured and what the acceptable range is.

13. Prepare a Story Demonstrating Supplier or Subcontractor Management — Even at a Small Scale

1–2 h

Skill: External interface management in a multi-vendor programme context

Objective: Supplier management experience is listed as a basic qualification on mid-level F-35 roles. Lockheed Martin is a system integrator on major defence programmes — a significant fraction of engineering work involves managing what external suppliers deliver and ensuring it meets requirements. Mid-level engineers who have only worked on fully in-house development miss a real LM context.

1–2 h

Done Signal: You have a story (even from a university capstone, a vendor selection exercise, or a small-scale professional context) where you defined what an external party needed to deliver, tracked their progress, found a gap, and resolved it. The story names the interface artefact (spec, ICD, drawing, test procedure) and the gap.

Source: Lockheed Martin

Senior Level (Level 3–5+)

All mid-level tasks still apply, but the clearance (tasks 2 and 5) must be active — not pending. EVMS (task 10) must be operational fluency from personal programme experience, not conceptual. MIL-STD (task 8) must include a practical compliance story — not just “I know the standard.”

14. Prepare to Walk Through a Full Programme-Level Technical Thread You Have Owned — from SOW to Verification Closure

4–6 h

Skill: Programme-level technical ownership narrative

Objective: Senior LM engineers are expected to generate, decompose, track, and verify requirements; perform risk assessments; lead trade studies; and write SOWs and supplier specifications across a complete programme thread. The interview at senior level is essentially a structured audit of whether you have actually done these things. Candidates who have done pieces of this — but cannot articulate the full thread — reveal that their “senior” experience was actually mid-level contribution on someone else’s programme.

Done Signal: For one programme thread you personally owned, you can answer questions at every phase: what the SOW or contract required, how you decomposed requirements, what the architecture decision was and why, what the V&V plan covered, what the hardest verification closure was, and what the programme office accepted as evidence.

Source: LinkedIn

15. Prepare a Structured Trade Study You Led — with Documented Methodology and a Defensible Conclusion

3–4 h

Skill: Trade study leadership and documentation

Objective: Trade studies are the primary decision-making mechanism at LM for significant technical choices. At senior level, you are expected to have led them — not participated. Leading a trade study means defining the criteria, assigning weights, gathering data from multiple disciplines, and producing a recommendation that survives scrutiny from the customer and programme office. Leading trade studies is called out explicitly as a senior systems engineering responsibility.

Done Signal: You can walk through one trade study you led: the decision being made, the criteria and their weights (and how those weights were justified), the alternatives evaluated, the data sources, and the recommendation — including the trade-offs you accepted and why the winning option was chosen over the runner-up.

Source: LinkedIn

16. Prepare Examples of Government Customer Interface — Specifically, Delivering Bad News or a Scope Change Request 2 h

Skill: Customer-facing technical communication in a DoD context

Objective: At senior level, LM engineers often sit across the table from the programme office or contracting officer's representative (COR). The government customer relationship is fundamentally different from a commercial one — changes require formal modification, bad news must be documented, and verbal agreements are not binding. Candidates who have never navigated this context are a risk at senior level.

Done Signal: You have a STAR story specifically about a difficult government customer interaction — a schedule slip, a design deviation, a cost growth, or a scope challenge — where the outcome involved a formal document (contract modification, engineering change proposal, deviation/waiver request) and you can describe your role in that process.

17. Build a Working Understanding of Integrated Product Team (IPT) Structure and How Senior Engineers Lead Within One 2–3 h

Skill: IPT leadership and cross-functional integration

Objective: Lockheed Martin organises large programmes around IPTs — cross-functional teams with authority over a defined product or system element. Senior engineers often lead or co-lead IPTs, which means owning both the technical and the programmatic health of their element. Candidates who do not understand IPT dynamics (how decisions are made, how issues are escalated, how schedule and cost are reported within one) are demonstrating they have not worked at a sufficient level in defence programmes.

Done Signal: You can explain IPT structure from memory, describe how a technical issue raised within an IPT gets escalated to a programme-level review, and give a personal example of a decision you drove or influenced within an IPT or equivalent cross-functional body.

18. Prepare a Story of Mentoring a Junior Engineer on a Programme-Specific Skill — with a Traceable Outcome on the Programme 1–2 h

Skill: Technical leadership and capability transfer in a compliance environment

Objective: LM programmes run for decades and institutional knowledge — about specific aircraft, specific suppliers, specific test configurations — is a critical asset. Senior engineers who transfer this knowledge to the next generation are valued. The difference from SpaceX's version of this question is that the LM version probes whether the knowledge transferred was programme-specific and whether it improved a deliverable, not just whether the junior engineer "grew."

Done Signal: You have a story where you taught a specific LM-programme-relevant skill (requirements writing in DOORS, reading an ICD, navigating a change control process, preparing for a PDR), the junior engineer applied it on the programme, and you can name the programme artefact that improved as a result.

All Levels**19. Prepare a Tight Answer to "Tell Me About a Time You Supported a Mission That Was More Important Than the Technology"** 1–2 h

Skill: Mission-driven purpose articulation specific to defence

Objective: Lockheed Martin is not a consumer company or a commercial manufacturer — it builds

1–2 h

systems that affect national security and the lives of military personnel. At every level, interviewers probe whether candidates understand this context and can connect their technical work to its operational purpose. This question appears across all levels; the expected depth of answer scales with seniority. An intern answer names the mission. A senior answer connects a specific technical decision to a specific operational outcome.

Done Signal: You have a story where the end user of what you built was not an abstract customer but a person, a mission, or a specific operational need — and your engineering decision was influenced by that context. The story names the operational context specifically, not just “defence applications.”

1–2 h

20. Document Your Clearance Status, Any Foreign National Contacts, and Be Ready to Discuss Them Without Hesitation

Skill: Security eligibility transparency and preparedness

Objective: The SF-86 security clearance questionnaire asks about foreign contacts, travel, financial history, drug use, and prior legal issues. Candidates who are caught off guard by these questions — or who have undisclosed items that surface in a background check — create serious problems. This is not a judgment call that can be prepared for in the interview room; it requires honest self-assessment before any offer stage. Recruiters specifically look for candidates who discuss their background with confidence and without evasion.

Done Signal: You have written down, honestly and completely, anything in your background that would appear on an SF-86 (foreign contacts, travel to flagged countries, prior drug use, financial judgments, etc.). You have a clear, factual one-sentence answer for each item. You have not rehearsed a story — you have rehearsed the truth, stated simply.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	STAR bank mapped to LM values	All	3–4 h
2	Security clearance process literacy	All	2–3 h
3	DoD acquisition lifecycle (CDR/PDR/Milestones)	All	3 h
4	Block diagram scenario practice	All	2–3 h
5	Clearance eligibility and relocation answers	All	1–2 h
6	ITAR/EAR regulatory awareness	All	2 h
7	Requirements traceability matrix	Mid+	4–5 h
8	MIL-STD study for your discipline	Mid+	5–6 h
9	Process-compliance-as-outcome stories	Mid+	2 h
10	EVMS conceptual fluency (SPI, CPI, EAC)	Mid+	3–4 h
11	Technical disagreement via right channels	Mid+	1–2 h
12	Vague stakeholder need → formal requirements	Mid+	3 h
13	Supplier/subcontractor management story	Mid+	1–2 h
14	Full programme thread from SOW to V&V closure	Senior	4–6 h
15	Trade study you led with documented methodology	Senior	3–4 h
16	Government customer bad-news story	Senior	2 h
17	IPT structure and leadership	Senior	2–3 h
18	Junior engineer mentoring with programme artefact	Senior	1–2 h
19	Mission-purpose answer (defence-specific)	All	1–2 h
20	SF-86 self-assessment and clearance transparency	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY

Lockheed Martin is the largest defence contractor in the world and one of the most process-governed engineering environments on earth. Its programmes are defined by government contracts, measured in decades, and subject to oversight from customers who have legal authority over deliverables, schedule, and scope. The engineer who thrives here is not the one who moves fastest — it is the one who knows how to move effectively within a structured, accountable system.

The central thing to internalise: **at LM, process is not friction — it is the product.** Documentation, traceability, formal reviews, and escalation channels exist because the programmes are too large, too long, and too consequential to run on informal agreement. Candidates who arrive ready to show they understand this — and can give real examples of working within it to produce better engineering outcomes — will consistently outperform those who treat it as bureaucratic overhead to be navigated around. Walk into every LM interview ready to demonstrate not just that you can build things, but that you can build the right things, in the right order, with the right people, in a way that someone can verify years from now.

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